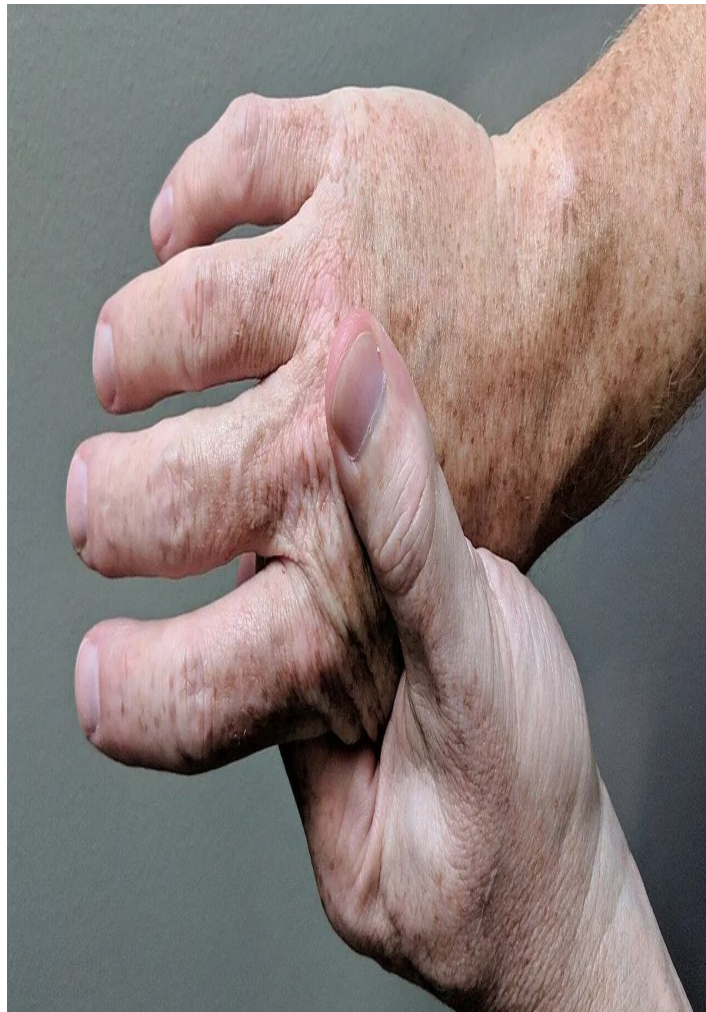


Travelling with Arthritis: A UK Guide to Pain-Free Holidays

Planning a holiday with arthritis? From flight tips to accessible destinations, here is your complete guide to travelling comfortably.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Travelling with Arthritis: Your Complete UK Guide



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Arthritis should never stop you from exploring the world. With smart planning and a few adjustments, you can enjoy holidays that leave you with memories — not flare-ups.

Before You Go

****Talk to your GP or rheumatologist**** at least 6 weeks before departure. They can: - Provide a medical letter for carrying medications through airport security - Adjust your medication schedule for time zone changes - Recommend travel-friendly pain relief options

****Insurance is essential.**** Always declare arthritis on your travel insurance — failing to do so could void your cover. Specialist providers like AllClear and Free Spirit cover pre-existing conditions at reasonable rates.



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Packing Smart

- ****Medication:**** Pack double what you need, split between hand luggage and hold luggage
- ****Compression socks:**** Reduce swelling on long flights or drives
- ****Heat/cold packs:**** Reusable gel packs are permitted in hold luggage
- ****Supportive shoes:**** Break them in before you travel
- ****Lightweight luggage:**** Choose bags with four spinner wheels and telescopic handles

During the Journey

****Flying:**** Request an aisle seat for extra legroom and the ability to stretch. Most airlines offer priority boarding and wheelchair assistance — book these in advance through Special Assistance. Stand and move every 30–45 minutes.



Openly licensed image via Openverse

****Driving:**** Stop every 90 minutes to stretch. Use cruise control where possible to reduce ankle strain. Heated seats can help stiff backs and hips.

Train travel: UK rail companies offer the Disabled Persons Railcard (£20/year), saving you a third on most fares. Book assistance through Passenger Assist at least 24 hours ahead.

Accessible UK Destinations

- **The Cotswolds:** Many accessible cottages with level-access showers and hot tubs
- **Lake District:** Accessible boat trips on Windermere; Brockhole visitor centre has excellent facilities
- **Cornwall:** The Eden Project offers mobility scooter hire and step-free access
- **Edinburgh:** Many hotels near the Royal Mile with lift access; hop-on buses reduce walking

Abroad: Top Tips

- **Mediterranean climates** (Spain, Portugal, Greece) are popular with arthritis patients — warmth eases stiffness
- **All-inclusive resorts** reduce the stress of planning and walking between restaurants
- **Cruise holidays** let you unpack once while visiting multiple destinations, and ships have excellent accessibility

Managing Flare-Ups Away from Home

Pack a "flare-up kit": topical anti-inflammatory gel (e.g., Voltarol), paracetamol, a cold compress, and a list of local pharmacies. The European Health Insurance Card (EHIC) or its replacement, the UK Global Health Insurance Card (GHIC), covers emergency treatment in EU countries.

Key Takeaway

The secret to arthritis-friendly travel is **planning, pacing, and permission to rest**. Choose destinations with good accessibility, pack thoughtfully, and don't be afraid to ask for help.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about travelling with arthritis: a uk guide to pain-free holidays?

Short answer: To travel with arthritis, consult your GP or rheumatologist at least six weeks before your trip to discuss medication and time zone changes. Always declare arthritis on travel insurance. Pack double the medication, split between hand and hold luggage. During travel, request assistance, stand and stretch frequently, and consider accessible destinations.

Planning, pacing, and permission to rest are key for a comfortable journey.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk